

Lionel Messi

There is very little left to write about Lionel Messi. His crowning moment at the 2022 World Cup felt like destiny's answer to the never-ending question of who the best player in the world was.

The 38-year-old now leads La Albiceleste into another global campaign, looking to become the first side to defend the title since Brazil in 1962.

Despite his advancing years, Messi continues to terrorise defences with his quick feet and world-class technical ability. In 12 Major League Soccer games in 2025/26, he has already tallied 11 goals and four assists for Inter Miami.

It will be an added bonus that the little magician gets to play on the North American continent, one he has fully acclimatised to over the last three seasons. While most players will arrive at the showpiece event after gruelling campaigns, Messi and the MLS contingent will be relatively fresh, with their new season starting only in late February following a winter break.

Despite retaining Lionel Scaloni as coach, Argentina is set to undergo quite a few changes from four years ago, with a significant injection of youth. These young stars will not have to look far for motivation. In what is surely set to be the great man's World Cup farewell, they have the opportunity to help him further cement his name into the bastion of FIFA World Cup legends.

ARGENTINA

Age - 38

Club - Inter Miami

NT Appearances - 198

Goals - 116

Assists - 64